

Impressive press

Around 1450, German publisher **Johannes Gutenberg** invented a printing press based on olive and wine presses.

His **mechanical movable type** system used metal letters arranged as required and inked by hand.

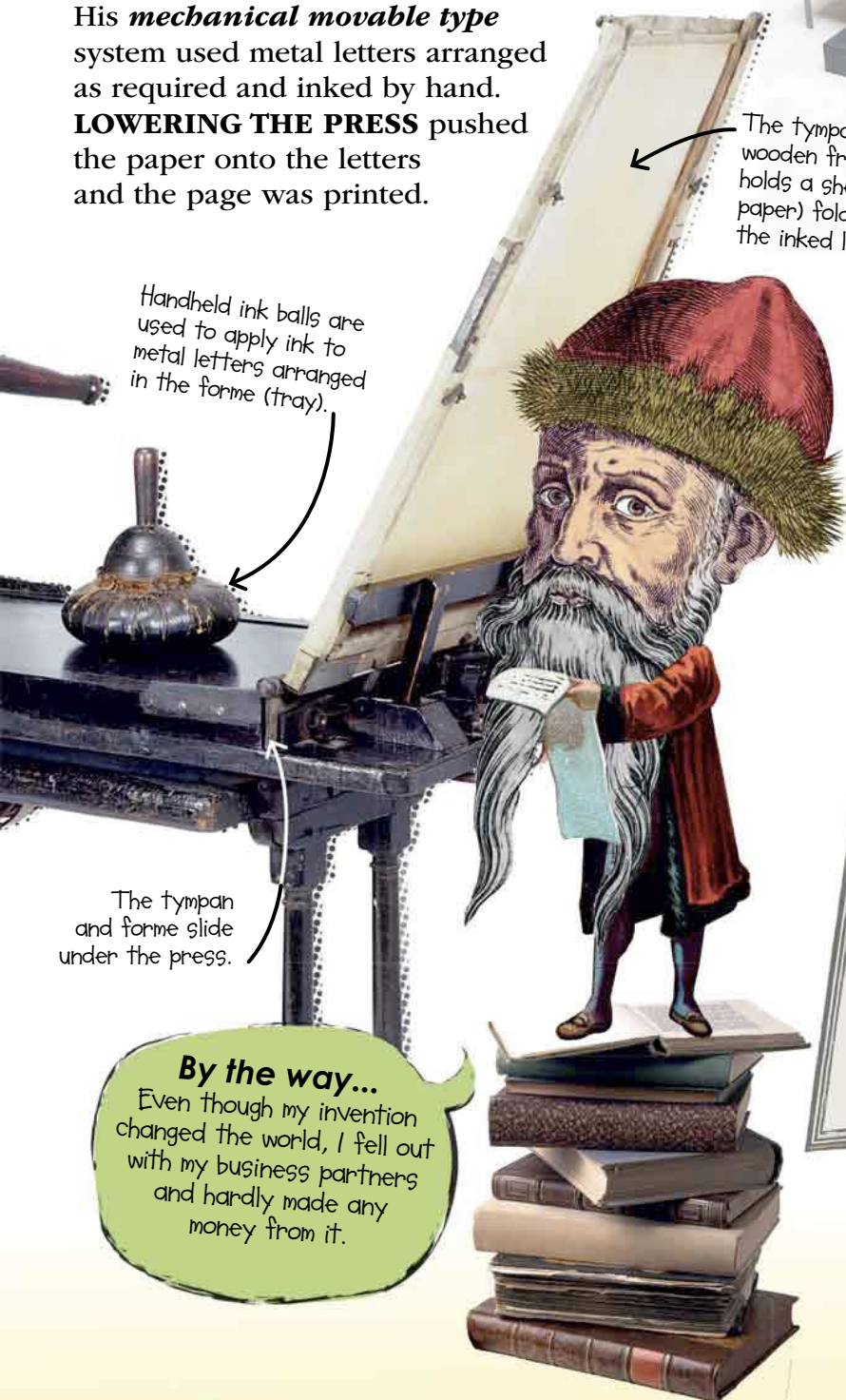
LOWERING THE PRESS pushed the paper onto the letters and the page was printed.



The tympan (the wooden frame that holds a sheet of paper) folds over onto the inked letters.

Printing today

Within Gutenberg's lifetime, his press produced books in cities **all over Europe**. He'd designed it so well that it hardly changed for the next **300 years**. Starting in the 1800s, steam-powered presses churned out books more cheaply than ever before. Modern presses (above), powered by electricity, use rollers and **PRINT IN COLOR**.



Handheld ink balls are used to apply ink to metal letters arranged in the forme (tray).

The tympan and forme slide under the press.

By the way...

Even though my invention changed the world, I fell out with my business partners and hardly made any money from it.

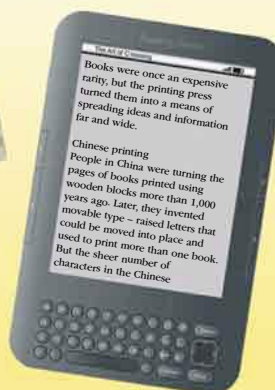
How it changed

Before Gutenberg's invention, books were rare and expensive because they had to be copied out by hand. The printing press meant that entire books could be printed cheaply and quickly, putting ideas and information into the hands of ordinary people, not just the very rich. Millions of people learned to read as a result and discovered the pleasure of a good book.

the world



PAPERBACK BOOKS were first mass-produced in the **19TH CENTURY** on steam-powered presses.



The first **E-BOOK READERS** were launched in **1998**. E-books will soon overtake sales of physical books.